

*Lontra canadensis*

North American river otter



Location Canada, USA

Length 23–29 in (58.3–73 cm)

Tail 12¼–18½ in (31.7–47 cm)

Weight 16–21 lb (7.3–9.4 kg)

Social unit Individual

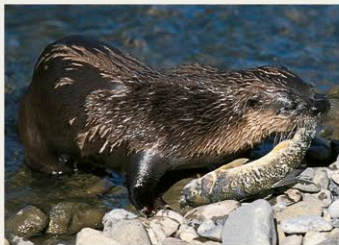
Status Least concern



Probably the most numerous otter, this species is similar to the Eurasian river otter (see below) and is solitary except at mating time, when it makes squeaks, chitters, and whistles. It dwells along riverbanks, lake shores, and coasts, maintaining territories of 3–15 miles (5–25 km). Home is a den in a riverside burrow, under a pile of rocks or a thicket near water, or in a beaver home (lodge).



HUNTER BY DAY OR NIGHT



The river otter's main prey is fish, which it catches by day, except in areas disturbed by people, where the otter becomes more nocturnal. Crayfish, frogs, snakes, lizards, and insects in the water are also devoured. Occasionally, this otter may also take an aquatic mammal such as a water vole, or a small waterbird such as a duckling.

SINUOUS AND SILVERY

This long-bodied otter has red- or gray-brown to black velvety fur on the back, paler silvery or gray-brown fur on the underparts, with the cheeks and throat tinged silver or yellow-gray.

muscular tail to aid swimming

*Aonyx capensis*

African clawless otter



Location W., E., C., and southern Africa

Length 29–35 in (73–88 cm)

Tail 18¼–20¼ in (46.5–51.5 cm)

Weight 22–46 lb (10–21 kg)

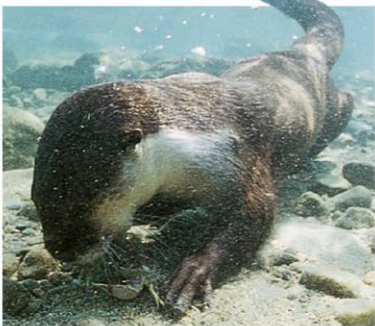
Social unit Pair/Group

Status Near threatened



As with other otters, the African clawless otter's long, sinuous body, muscular tail, and short limbs make it well adapted to swim and dive. It catches crabs, frogs, and fish, as well as lobster and octopus along coasts, crushing them with its large

teeth. The rear feet are webbed with small claws on toes 3 and 4. The clawless front toes resemble fingers, and are able to feel and hold prey. The clans of paired adults and 2–3 young are exceptionally playful, enjoying mock fighting, mud sliding, and noisy, yapping chases.



*Aonyx cinereus*

Asian small-clawed otter



Location S., E., and S.E. Asia

Length 14–18½ in (36–47 cm)

Tail 9–10¾ in (22.5–27.5 cm)

Weight 5¼–8¼ lb (2.4–3.8 kg)

Social unit Pair/Group

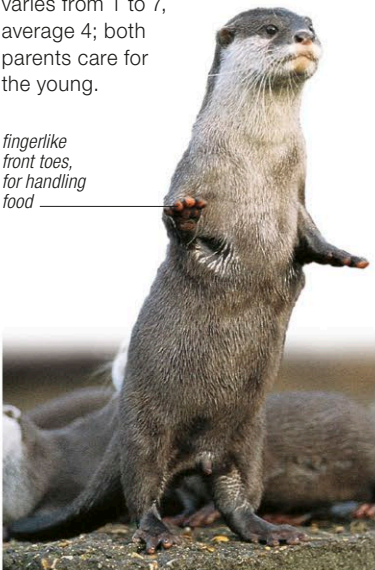
Status Vulnerable



Smallest of the otters, the Asian small-clawed otter has very short claws that do not extend beyond the fleshy end pads of the partly webbed toes. The cheek teeth are broad, for crushing hard-cased food such as mussels and other shellfish, crabs, and frogs; unusually for otters, fish are relatively unimportant in the diet. The upperparts are brown; the underside is paler, with variable white areas on the lower face, throat, and chest. These otters form loose social groups of about

12, members keeping in touch with noises and scents. Male–female pair-bonds are especially strong. As in many similar species, territories are marked with scent from paired glands at the base of the tail, urine, and droppings (spraints). Litter size varies from 1 to 7, average 4; both parents care for the young.

fingerlike front toes, for handling food



*Lutra lutra*

Eurasian otter



Location Europe, Asia

Length 20–32 in (50–82 cm)

Tail 13–20 in (33–50 cm)

Weight 11–31 lb (5–14 kg)

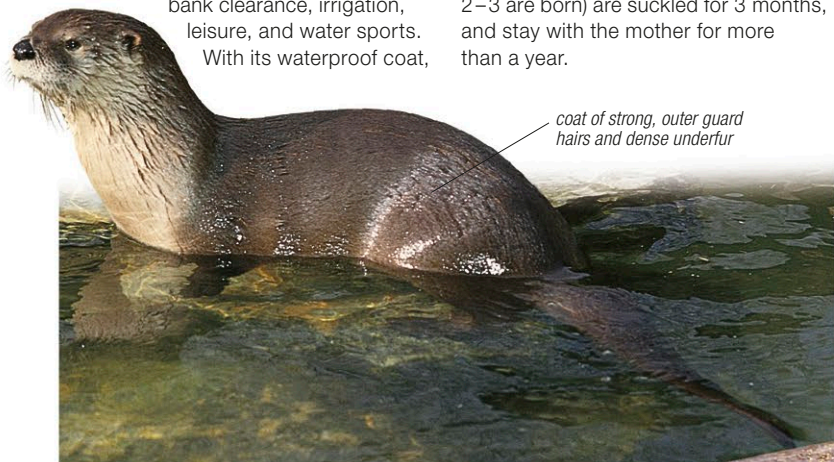
Social unit Individual

Status Near threatened



The Eurasian otter has suffered through hunting for fur, fishery protection, and sports, as well as from water pollution and loss of river habitat caused by bank clearance, irrigation, leisure, and water sports. With its waterproof coat,

webbed paws, and stiff whiskers (to feel currents from prey movement), this otter is well adapted to its aquatic habitat. It hunts mainly fish, as well as frogs and other aquatic or amphibious prey. Its coloration is mainly brown, with a paler throat, and the muscular tail is flattened from top to bottom. Inland, the Eurasian river otter hunts chiefly in twilight or darkness, while along coasts, it is more active in daylight. The burrow (holt) is in a bankside territory, 2½–12 miles (4–20 km) long, marked by scent and droppings. The Eurasian river otter is mostly solitary, pairing for 2–3 months in early spring. After 60–63 days' gestation, the 1–5 cubs (on average 2–3 are born) are suckled for 3 months, and stay with the mother for more than a year.



*Pteronura brasiliensis*

Giant otter



Location N. and C. South America

Length 3¼–4½ ft (1–1.4 m)

Tail 18–26 in (45–65 cm)

Weight 49–71 lb (22–32 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Endangered



The biggest mustelid, this species is similar to a very large river otter. It has short legs, well-webbed toes, and a flattened, wide-based tail, for swimming and diving. Its stout whiskers and sensitive

eyes effectively detect prey movements in water. Being so aquatic, it is ungainly on land. The short, dense fur is dark brown, appearing black when wet, with cream spots and patches on the chin, throat, and chest, which may merge into a "bib." The giant otter forms groups of 4–8, going up to 20: usually comprising 2 parents, their offspring, and various younger adults. They live in a communal bank den or burrow and hunt by day for fish, crabs, and other aquatic prey.

